WORKING DRAFT · FOR AUTHOR REVIEW

LETTERS CONFLICT

ORIGINS

The Anatomy of the Conflict

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Chapters 1–4 · Draft · 2026-10-31

A Note to the Reader

This book is a history written as literature. It moves between documented events and reflection, between stone and story, and you deserve to know at every point which is which.

Four kinds of material appear in these pages.

Established history — conclusions strongly supported by archaeology, written records or careful scholarship. These carry a number in square brackets that leads to the Research Notes and Sources at the back of the book.

Scholarly debate — questions on which serious historians disagree. Where they do, the book says so and names the positions rather than quietly choosing the most dramatic one.

Oral tradition — accounts carried across generations by speech, song and teaching. They are treated as living evidence, with attention to who carries them, when they were recorded and how they have changed.

The author's interpretation — the meaning I draw from the evidence. The central image of this trilogy, that people are letters and institutions are grammar, belongs here. It is a way of seeing, not a historical finding.

Illustrations introduced with "imagine" or "suppose" are teaching devices, not reports. No quotation, conversation or private thought has been invented for a historical person. Where a scene is reconstructed from the record, the text says so.

Africa is not one country, one people or one story. Wherever it matters, this book names the society, the region and the century.

The prose carries the story. The notes carry the evidence. Read the first for the journey; consult the second whenever you want to check the road.

Chapter 1

The Story Before the Wound

> *"Until the lions have their own historians, the history of the hunt will always glorify the hunter."*
>
> — Proverb, as cited by Chinua Achebe

In 1871 a German geologist named Karl Mauch walked into a valley in what is now south-eastern Zimbabwe. He was looking for gold. What he found was stone.

On a granite hill stood walls fitted without mortar, course laid upon course, following the shapes of the boulders as though the rock itself had been persuaded to rise. In the valley below, a great curving wall enclosed an open space and a tall conical tower. The walls of that enclosure reach more than ten metres in height and run for some 250 metres. The people who raised them had split granite from the surrounding hills into even blocks and stepped each course slightly back from the one beneath it, so that the whole structure leans gently inward and holds itself up. [1] The Shona word *Zimbabwe* is usually rendered "house in stone". [2]

Mauch looked at the walls and saw the Bible. The ruins, he decided, were the palace of the Queen of Sheba, raised in the land of Ophir in imitation of Solomon's temple. When he examined a wooden beam set into one of the walls, he concluded that it was cedar, that cedar meant Lebanon, and that Phoenician traders must have carried it south. [3]

He did not conclude that the people farming that valley might be descended from the builders. In his judgement the walls were too accomplished to be theirs.

This book begins with that judgement. Not because Mauch was important — he was one traveller among many — but because his mistake holds the whole problem in miniature. The evidence stood in front of him. He touched it, measured it and drew it. And still the story he told about it had been decided before he arrived.

The walls did not change. The story around them did.

The question this trilogy follows is a large one. How did societies that built so much — cities, kingdoms, scholarship, law and long-distance trade — arrive at a present in which so many of their institutions struggle to turn human ability into shared progress? That question cannot be asked honestly until a smaller one has been answered first. Who has been telling the story, and what did they need it to say?

A Century of Argument Around a Wall

After Mauch, Great Zimbabwe became more than a ruin. It became an argument, and the argument became political.

In 1891 the English traveller Theodore Bent excavated at the site. His work, like that of the man who followed him, was sponsored by Cecil Rhodes, whose British South Africa Company was then taking control of the territory. [3] Bent credited the building to peoples from outside Africa, the "Semites" or "Hamites" of the racial vocabulary of his day. [4] The conclusion was convenient. A land whose greatest monument had been built by ancient outsiders could be presented as a land waiting for modern outsiders to return.

In 1902 Richard Nicklin Hall was engaged to examine and preserve the ruins on behalf of the new colonial government. He spent two years at the work. His own account, published in 1905, records the method: from each enclosure his workers removed "all débris and fallen stones to a depth of from 4 ft. to 7 ft." [5]

To an archaeologist, soil is an archive. Layers of earth record the order in which people lived, built, cooked, traded and left. Objects found in sequence can tell a story that no single object can. Hall believed the original builders were ancient and foreign, and he regarded much of what lay above the old floors as the debris of later, lesser occupation. Of some walls he wrote: "Some are constructions by indigenous peoples, and certainly they are not ancient." [5] In clearing the site he shovelled away a great

part of the sequence that could have answered the very question he believed he was settling. [4]

The correction came from professional archaeology. In 1905 the archaeologist David Randall-MacIver concluded that the buildings were African and medieval. In 1929 the British Association for the Advancement of Science invited Gertrude Caton-Thompson to investigate. She confirmed Randall-MacIver's conclusion that the ruins belonged to an indigenous African culture and found evidence of their links with Indian Ocean trade. [6] Her book *The Zimbabwe Culture* appeared in 1931. [4]

The evidence was now settled among specialists. The argument was not. The archaeologist Shadreck Chirikure describes how trained researchers supported a local origin while state-sponsored amateurs went on insisting that Great Zimbabwe was foreign. [4]

In 1965 Ian Smith's government declared Rhodesia independent of Britain in order to preserve white minority rule. [3] The old question returned with new force. In 1966 a member of the ruling party's executive was appointed to the Historical Monuments Commission. In 1968 and again in 1969 the national Censorship Board indicated that it intended to have museum displays on Zimbabwe altered. In 1969 a minister instructed that information on the site's origins should "indicate quite clearly that, as yet, no irrefutable evidence is available." [7]

Peter Garlake, who had served as the country's Inspector of Monuments since 1964 and whose research identified the builders as ancestors of the Shona, left Rhodesia in 1970. [8] Other professionals resigned, among them Roger Summers. [7] A new official guidebook was prepared. When the editors of the archaeological journal *Antiquity* examined it in 1974, they found material on psychic experiences, dowsing and Phoenician colonisation, and judged that it could be considered "unacceptable and even a little shaming." [7]

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

It is often said that the Rhodesian government banned archaeologists from saying that Africans built Great Zimbabwe. The record is more complicated, and more instructive.

Writing in 1974, Garlake himself said that he knew of no evidence that archaeological material had been censored, and had never claimed it. [7] Scholars could still publish in learned journals. The pressure fell elsewhere: on the guidebooks, museum displays and official statements through which ordinary citizens and schoolchildren met the past.

Nobody needed to deny the evidence. It was enough to insist that the question remained open, and to set dowsers beside archaeologists as though they were equal witnesses.

That is a lesson this book will need again. A false story does not always require a lie. Sometimes it requires only a false balance, repeated in the places where most people learn what they know.

On 18 April 1980 the Republic of Zimbabwe was proclaimed. Its new flag carried the Zimbabwe Bird, a figure taken from the soapstone carvings found at the site. [9] A nation took the name of the place whose builders it had been told were strangers, and put their work on its flag.

The walls had waited more than five centuries. They had outlasted Mauch, Bent and Hall, the colonial company and the government that tried to keep their question open. What they could not do on their own was teach the next generation what they meant. Stone survives. Understanding has to be handed on.

The Philosopher, the Explorer and the Professor

Great Zimbabwe was not an isolated misunderstanding. It was one local expression of a larger idea: that Africa stood outside history altogether.

In the 1820s the German philosopher Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel lectured in Berlin on the philosophy of world history. He had never set foot in Africa. In the translated text of those

lectures he dismisses the continent in two sentences: “At this point we leave Africa, not to mention it again. For it is no historical part of the World; it has no movement or development to exhibit.” [10]

Hegel was not reporting evidence. He was assigning Africa a place in a system he had already built, in which history meant the progress of a particular kind of state toward a particular kind of freedom. Whoever did not fit the system was declared to have no history at all.

Later in the century Hegel’s abstraction acquired a popular name. In 1878 the explorer Henry Morton Stanley published the account of his crossing of the continent under the title *Through the Dark Continent*. [11] “Dark” had once meant little more than unknown to European maps. The literary scholar Patrick Brantlinger has traced how, across the Victorian decades, the word came to mean something else: a moral and racial darkness that imperial rule promised to illuminate. [12] The phrase justified conquest by describing the conquered as people without light.

The irony sits inside Stanley’s own journey. In 1875 he reached the court of Kabaka Mutesa I of Buganda, on the northern shores of Lake Victoria: a kingdom with its own ruler, chiefs, capital and remembered history, whose story belongs to Chapter 5. From there he published an appeal for Christian missionaries to be sent to Buganda, and the Church Missionary Society began its Uganda mission two years later. [13] The traveller who called a continent dark had sat in the court of an organised African state.

The word outlived the journey. In time, many Africans would learn to describe their own past with it.

More than a century later the idea was still alive in one of the most prestigious chairs in the English-speaking world. In 1963 Hugh Trevor-Roper, Regius Professor of Modern History at Oxford, told a BBC audience: “Perhaps in the future, there will be some African history to teach. But, at present there is none: there is only the history of the Europeans in Africa. The rest is darkness…” [14]

He was wrong, and by then the proof was already in print. Seven years earlier the Nigerian historian Kenneth Onwuka Dike had published *Trade and Politics in the Niger Delta, 1830–1885*. Dike placed African traders, rulers and communities at the centre of their own history and combined written documents with oral evidence to do it. His work helped found what became known as the Ibadan school of African history. [15]

In 1964, the year after Trevor-Roper's broadcast, UNESCO launched the *General History of Africa*, a project that would draw on hundreds of African and international scholars and approach the continent's past from African perspectives. [16] Its first volume, edited by the Burkinabè historian Joseph Ki-Zerbo and published in 1981, did not begin with kings or conquests. It began with method: how African history can be known at all. [16]

The Nigerian novelist Chinua Achebe once cited a proverb that sums up what was at stake: until the lions have their own historians, the history of the hunt will always glorify the hunter. [17]

But the proverb carries a warning for the lions too. A history written by the hunted can also flatter its tellers. It can turn every ancestor into a hero, every kingdom into a paradise and every difficulty into someone else's fault. Replacing an insulting story with a flattering one does not complete the work of history. It only changes who is being flattered.

The task of this book is harder than reversing Hegel. It is to let African societies appear as they were: makers and borrowers, builders and conquerors, scholars and slave-holders, people capable of wisdom and of error, like human beings everywhere. We do our ancestors little honour by making them too perfect to have lived.

Three Witnesses

How, then, do we know anything about the African past? Through three kinds of witness, each with its own strengths and its own blind spots.

The stone. Archaeology reads the material world: walls, floors, tools, seeds, bones and the layers of earth that hold them. It is the witness that Hall's workmen silenced, and it keeps speaking where it is allowed to. At Great Zimbabwe, for example, the finding of sixteenth-century Chinese porcelain in the Valley Enclosures and newer radiocarbon dating have shown that the city did not simply collapse around 1450, as was long believed, but ebbed and flowed into the seventeenth century. [4] Even settled conclusions get revised when the stone is read more carefully.

The page. Written records — chronicles, letters, contracts, legal opinions, travellers' accounts — give us names, dates and arguments. Africa produced many of them, in Ge'ez, Arabic, Ajami and other scripts, and the manuscripts of Timbuktu will occupy us in Chapter 3. But a page records what someone chose to write. A law tells us what a ruler intended, not whether it was obeyed. A traveller's account tells us what a visitor noticed, and sometimes what he expected to find.

The voice. Much African history was carried by speech: genealogies, praise poetry, clan histories, songs and the teaching of elders. The Belgian historian Jan Vansina, who spent much of his career studying the kingdoms of Central Africa, helped make the use of oral tradition as historical evidence a subject of careful method. [18] Such accounts preserve knowledge that no excavation could recover. They also change as they pass from one teller to the next, and they serve the communities that carry them. So we ask of them what we should ask of any witness: who is speaking, from whom did they learn it, when was it written down, and do other tellers say something different?

No witness is complete. The stone has no words. The page has an author with interests. The voice has travelled through many mouths. History is the work of letting the three cross-examine one another.

Beyond the Wall

Return for a moment to the valley Mauch entered. The question he got wrong was “Who built this?” But even the right answer — the ancestors of the Shona — can hide almost everyone involved.

A wall like the Great Enclosure is not built by a name. Someone had to learn how granite splits. Someone had to quarry it, carry it and set it. Someone had to grow the grain and keep the cattle that fed the builders. Traders carried gold from the interior toward the coast; coins from Kilwa, glass beads and Chinese and Persian porcelain found at the site show how far those connections reached. [2]

Recent scholarship has pushed attention in exactly this direction. Chirikure argues that accounts of Great Zimbabwe have centred too heavily on rulers and imported luxuries, and that the households and local production of ordinary people deserve a much larger place in explaining how the city worked. [4] That does not make the society equal or its rulers powerless. It changes where we look.

This book will try to look in both places: at the walls and at the hands, at the kings and at the households that fed them. A civilisation is not only its monuments. It is the arrangements that allow thousands of people to contribute to something none of them could build alone.

And Great Zimbabwe is only one page. Long before its walls rose, the Kingdom of Kush had built royal cities, temples and water works around Meroë in what is now Sudan. [19] Aksum, in the highlands of present-day Ethiopia and Eritrea, traded across the Red Sea and began minting its own coins in the third century. [20] On the coast of present-day Tanzania, the Swahili towns of Kilwa Kisiwani and Songo Mnara built houses and mosques of stone and coral and traded across the Indian Ocean. [21]

These places are separated by thousands of kilometres and many centuries. They cannot be pressed into a single African golden age. Each has its own chronology, its own achievements

and its own failures. The chapters that follow will take them one at a time.

A Past with Contradictions

Recovering achievement brings relief. Something dismissed becomes visible. Something declared impossible becomes undeniable. But relief can harden into defensiveness, until every difficult finding feels like an attack on belonging.

Consider the manuscripts of Timbuktu shown by the Library of Congress in 2003. Among them were a text on the laws of commerce composed in verse and a primer for teaching arithmetic. Beside them were a document concerning the sale and transport of enslaved people and a certificate granting freedom to an enslaved woman. [22]

Those documents belong together. A society can produce sophisticated scholarship and hold human beings as property in the same centuries and the same cities. Recognising the scholarship does not approve the slavery. Recognising the slavery does not deny the scholarship. Both are true, and an honest history has to carry both.

The same honesty applies when the subject becomes conquest. The existence of conflict and injustice inside African societies never justified invasion from outside. And invasion from outside does not make every African exercise of power innocent. Different people bear different responsibilities within the same history.

That is also why this book will be careful with two small words: “Africa” and “we”. A ruler who sold captives, a trader who carried them, the captive and the person who hid from the raiders were all African. They did not share the same interests, the same power or the same guilt. To write that “Africa chose” something would require us to say who chose, whom they could command and who resisted them. The continent is not a single character, and its history is not a single plot.

The past becomes useful when it is allowed to challenge us. If it only confirms what we already wish to believe, we should look again at how we selected it.

The Letters and Their Relationships

Place six letters on a page: A, F, R, I, C, A. We recognise the word because of their order and because we have learned to read it. Change the arrangement and the meaning changes, or disappears.

That is the image behind this trilogy. People are the letters: distinct, each with its own shape, its own sound and its own dignity. Institutions are the grammar: the rules and practices by which people exercise authority, make decisions, share responsibilities and settle disputes. Shared progress is the sentence: what people can build together that none of them could build alone.

The image has limits, and they matter as much as the image itself. People are not marks waiting for a powerful hand to place them. They can object, refuse, imagine alternatives and change the rules under which they cooperate. A person keeps their worth when an institution fails them, when their contribution is overlooked, or when they cannot contribute at all. No ruler, reformer or author is entitled to arrange human beings as passive letters in a sentence of his own choosing. And the word *Africa* itself teaches the most important lesson: it needs different letters. Six identical letters would spell nothing.

Imagine a group of neighbours who agree to maintain a shared well. Their goodwill is not enough. Who digs? Who decides what repair is needed? What happens to a family that cannot contribute, and how is that different from a family that will not? How can someone challenge an unfair demand? The well will be kept only if the neighbours find answers they can trust. That is grammar.

Grammar can also be bent toward bad sentences. People can organise efficiently around an abusive purpose. A system that

coordinates well is not, for that reason alone, a just one. So this book will ask two questions of every arrangement it examines: how did it work, and what did it require people to endure?

The title *Origins* might suggest a single morning on which the letters were scattered. There was no such morning. Every point at which we enter African history has something before it. Institutions kept old names while changing their purposes. Practices survived by adapting. Some arrangements were imposed from outside; others were made, or remade, by Africans themselves. The conflict was not created in a day. It accumulated.

The Question We Will Follow

The chapters ahead move through selected African worlds before turning to the forces that broke and reshaped them. Part One visits the Nile and the Horn, the Sahel, the stone and coastal cities of the south and east, the kingdoms of the forest, and the many ways African societies, including the kingdoms of the Great Lakes, organised power. Part Two follows the trades in human beings and the conquest that drew new borders across living worlds. Part Three asks what independence inherited, what Africans did with that inheritance, and how documented greatness came to sound, to many of its own descendants, like a fairy tale.

That route does not mean every African society passed through the same stages. Nor does it mean the present was inevitable. The people living through these histories could not see how their stories would end. Wherever the evidence allows, we will try to recover the choices that were open to them, so that we can tell the difference between a constraint we inherited and a habit we have chosen to keep.

There will be injuries for which responsibility must be named. There will be achievements that deserve to be known. There will be decisions whose consequences were mixed, contested or very different from what their makers intended. A general

accusation produces anger without direction. A precise explanation can show where authority sat, how an incentive worked and why a correction failed. Only the second can help us build anything.

The Letter Principle

A people can lose its history in two ways. Others can take the authorship of its achievements, as the travellers and officials took the walls of Great Zimbabwe. Or its own children can stop asking how those achievements were made, and keep only the pride or only the grievance. Both losses leave the letters without their grammar. To recover a history is not to choose the most comforting story. It is to recover the full sentence — the builders and the burdens, the brilliance and the injustice — so that we can understand what it once took to make meaning together, and what it would take to do it again.

Questions for Reflection

1. Before reading this chapter, had you heard of Great Zimbabwe, and who did you assume had built it? Where did that knowledge, or its absence, come from?
2. Karl Mauch saw the evidence and still told the wrong story. What assumptions might shape how you read the evidence about your own society today?
3. The Rhodesian guidebook did not deny the evidence; it insisted on “balance”. Where do you see false balance used to keep a settled question open?
4. Whose stories are missing from the history you were taught at school? Who in your family or community still carries them?
5. Can you admire an achievement while acknowledging the injustice inside the society that produced it? Choose an example from your own country’s past.

* * *

The walls are still standing in their valley. They were not waiting for a stranger to explain them, and they are not waiting for us to worship them. They are waiting, as all evidence waits, to be read honestly.

The next chapter turns north, to the Nile and the Horn, where queens of Kush made war on Rome and the kings of Aksum stamped their names in gold.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 2

Nile, Kush, and the Horn

> *“Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God.”*
>
> — Psalm 68:31 (King James Version)

In December 1910 a team led by the British archaeologist John Garstang was digging at Meroë, the old royal city of Kush on the east bank of the Nile in what is now Sudan. Beneath the staircase of a small temple, in a pocket of clean sand about two and a half metres below the surface, the workers uncovered a bronze head of heroic size. [23]

At first the excavators thought it showed the Roman prince Germanicus. Comparison with other portraits settled the question. It was Augustus, the first emperor of Rome, cast in bronze within a few years of 27 BCE, larger than life, and preserved for more than nineteen centuries by the dry heat of the Sudanese desert. It is now in the British Museum. [23]

A Roman emperor’s head had no obvious reason to be in Meroë, more than a thousand kilometres south of the nearest Roman garrison. And it had even less reason to be buried under a doorstep, in a temple whose walls were painted with bound prisoners, where everyone who climbed the stairs would walk over the face of the most powerful man in the Mediterranean world. [23]

The explanation lies in a war that Roman writers recorded and Kushite writers recorded in a language we still cannot fully read. To follow it, we have to set aside one of the oldest habits in the telling of African history: the habit of meeting Africa only when someone from elsewhere arrives.

This chapter asks a simple question about the Nile and the Horn of Africa. What did it take for societies here to build states that could negotiate with Rome, rule Egypt and trade across the Red Sea, and who carried the weight of that power?

A Queen Against Rome

The Greek geographer Strabo, a contemporary of these events, tells the story from the Roman side. In the mid-20s BCE, while part of the Roman army in Egypt was away on campaign in Arabia, an army from the south crossed the frontier at the First Cataract of the Nile. It took Syene, Elephantine and Philae. According to Strabo, the invaders "enslaved the inhabitants, and also pulled down the statues of Caesar." [24]

The Roman prefect Gaius Petronius struck back "with less than ten thousand infantry and eight hundred cavalry against thirty thousand men". He drove the southern army back, took the fortified towns of Pselchis and Premnis, and pushed upriver as far as Napata, an ancient royal centre of Kush, which he razed. [24]

Strabo calls the ruler of the southern kingdom Candace and describes her, through Roman eyes, as "a masculine sort of woman, and blind in one eye." [24] The name was in fact a title. *Kandake* was the word Kushites used for a royal woman of the highest rank, and inscriptions at Meroë and Naqa name a queen who carried both that title and the title *qore*, ruler: Amanirenas. Most historians identify her as Strabo's Candace. The identification rests on her titles and on inscriptions in the Meroitic language, which remains only partly understood, so it is a strong inference rather than a certainty. [25]

The war did not end with a Roman march on Meroë. Strabo records that the queen sent envoys to negotiate. Petronius passed them on to Augustus, who was then on the Greek island of Samos. The envoys obtained what they asked for, and the emperor "even remitted the tributes which he had imposed." [24] A frontier zone was agreed between the two powers, and the Kushite capital was never taken. [25]

The head beneath the steps belongs to the opening of that war. It is most likely one of the statues of Augustus pulled down in the raid on Roman Egypt, carried south as a trophy and buried at the threshold of a shrine to victory. [23]

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

In recent years the story of Amanirenas has travelled widely as the tale of "the one-eyed African queen who defeated Rome." The record is more interesting than the slogan.

Kush did not defeat Rome in battle. A Roman army penetrated deep into Kushite territory and destroyed Napata. What Kush achieved was something rarer and, for the people living along the Nile, more useful. It fought the most powerful empire of its age to a standstill, then negotiated a peace on better terms than Rome usually granted: no tribute, an agreed frontier and a capital left standing. [24][25]

That is a lesson in statecraft, not only in courage. A kingdom that can raise an army, sustain a war, send envoys across the Mediterranean and bargain with an emperor is a kingdom with institutions — treasuries, officials, messengers, records and a court able to decide what it wanted. The slogan remembers the queen. The evidence asks us to remember the state.

Older Than Rome

By the time Amanirenas faced Rome, Kush was already ancient. Its story is usually told as a footnote to Egypt's, as though the lands south of the First Cataract were a frontier province waiting to be civilised from the north. The evidence says otherwise.

Around 2500 BCE a state formed at Kerma, near the Third Cataract of the Nile. Its capital grew around a massive mud-brick temple known today as the Western Deffufa, whose base measures more than fifty metres by twenty-six. By about 1700 BCE the city had at least ten thousand inhabitants, and its cemetery holds more than thirty thousand graves. [26]

The American archaeologist George Reisner, who excavated Kerma early in the twentieth century, assumed it had been an Egyptian outpost and read its great temple as a fort. Decades of later excavation by the Swiss archaeologist Charles Bonnet showed instead a large, independent African city with its own architecture, burial customs and political power, trading with

Egypt rather than serving it. [26] It is the same pattern we met at Great Zimbabwe: a monument attributed to outsiders until the evidence was read on its own terms.

Egypt's New Kingdom eventually conquered Upper Nubia, and for several centuries the region was ruled from the north. [26] But Kush revived around Napata and the sacred mountain of Jebel Barkal, and in the eighth century BCE the direction of power reversed.

Around 728 BCE the Kushite king Piye marched north and defeated a coalition of rulers in the Nile Delta. He recorded the campaign on a great victory stela. His successors took the full titles of pharaoh, and Kushite kings ruled Egypt as its Twenty-fifth Dynasty until the 650s BCE. [27] One of them, Taharqa, who ruled from 690 to 664 BCE, appears in the Hebrew Bible as "Tirhakah king of Ethiopia" — the Hebrew text says Kush — marching out against the Assyrian king Sennacherib. [27][28] It was the Assyrians, in the end, who drove the Kushite pharaohs out of Egypt. [27]

So the relationship between Egypt and Kush was not that of a teacher and a pupil. At some times Egypt ruled Kush. At others Kush ruled Egypt. For most of three thousand years they traded, fought, married, worshipped and borrowed from each other. Both were African.

Meroë: Iron, Water and a Script We Cannot Yet Read

From the third century BCE onward, most Kushite royal burials took place at Meroë, further south, where the kingdom's heartland lay between the Nile and the Atbara. UNESCO describes the Kingdom of Kush as a major power from the eighth century BCE to the fourth century CE, and the remains around Meroë include pyramids, temples, palaces, industrial areas and installations for storing water. [19][29] Royal pyramids still stand in clusters on the ridges east of the city, steeper and smaller than those of Egypt, more numerous than most visitors expect.

Meroë was also a city of fire. Excavations have found furnaces and great mounds of slag, the glassy waste left by smelting iron. New radiocarbon dates suggest that iron was being produced there on a significant scale by the seventh or sixth century BCE, and that production continued for more than a thousand years. The archaeologists now working on the site describe Meroë as one of the largest ironmaking centres in Africa. [30] Iron meant tools for farmers, weapons for armies and goods for trade. It also meant fuel, labour and knowledge passed carefully from one generation of smelters to the next.

And Meroë wrote. From about the third century BCE the Kushites used a script of their own, in two forms: a monumental hieroglyphic form for temples and a cursive form for everyday use. Its twenty-three signs record the Meroitic language. In 1909 the British Egyptologist Francis Llewellyn Griffith worked out the sound values of the signs, using Egyptian names spelled in Meroitic. [31]

That was a remarkable achievement, and it left a strange result. We can now read Meroitic aloud. We can pronounce the names of its queens and gods and the words on their monuments. But the language itself remains poorly understood. [31] Most of its sentences are still closed to us.

There is no image in African history closer to the heart of this trilogy. The letters survive. We can sound every one of them. What we have lost is the grammar that once made them mean.

When UNESCO convened scholars in Cairo in 1974 for the *General History of Africa*, the second part of the meeting was devoted to the decipherment of Meroitic. Among its recommendations was that Sudanese students be trained in the languages of Sudan, so that the work of understanding could be carried on by the people closest to it. [32]

Kush was known far beyond its borders in its own time. The New Testament records the conversion of an official from this kingdom, “an eunuch of great authority under Candace queen of the Ethiopians, who had the charge of all her treasure.” [28] The writer used the same royal title Strabo had heard. A Kushite

treasurer returning from Jerusalem and reading the prophet Isaiah in his chariot tells us something no pyramid can: that this was a state with officials, finances, literacy and connections that reached across the known world.

Who Carried the Weight

It would be easy to stop there, with queens and pyramids, iron and treasure. But this book promised to look at the hands as well as the walls.

Kush's power was not gentle. Strabo's account opens with a Kushite army enslaving the inhabitants of the towns it captured. [24] The temple where the head of Augustus was buried was painted with bound prisoners beneath a ruler's feet. [23] Pyramids, temples and furnaces required the labour of many people who left no names, and the fuel for a thousand years of smelting had to come from somewhere. The surviving evidence tells us far more about the rulers who commanded that labour than about the people who performed it.

Nor was Kush only a victim of larger empires. It was itself a power that raided, conquered and ruled. In the fourth century CE, as Meroë declined, it in turn became the target of a rising kingdom in the highlands to the east.

An inscription of King Ezana of Aksum, from about the middle of the fourth century, describes a campaign against the Noba along the rivers of the Nile valley: villages burned, goods seized, enemies pursued for days. As transcribed by historians, it lists prisoners — 214 men and 415 women — alongside the dead and many thousands of captured cattle and sheep. [33] Behind each number was a person taken from a home.

These records do not cancel the achievements of Kush or Aksum. They complete them. States that could build and trade could also capture and enslave, and the same institutions that organised a treasury could organise a raid. An honest history keeps both in the same frame.

Aksum: A Kingdom Between Empires

Aksum rose in the highlands of what are now northern Ethiopia and Eritrea, and lasted, as a kingdom, from roughly the first to the eighth century CE. UNESCO calls it "the most powerful state between the Eastern Roman Empire and Persia." [34] Through its Red Sea port at Adulis it traded with Egypt, Arabia, the Mediterranean and India, and from the third century it minted its own coins in gold, silver and bronze. [20][35]

Its rulers marked their capital with stone stelae carved to resemble many-storeyed buildings, with false doors and windows cut into the granite. The largest still standing rises more than twenty-three metres. The largest of all, some thirty-three metres long, lies broken where it fell. [34]

Under Ezana, in the middle of the fourth century, the kingdom turned to Christianity, a change associated with a missionary named Frumentius. On Ezana's coins the old symbol of the sun and moon gives way to the cross. [35] His inscriptions were written in three languages — Greek for the wider world, the old South Arabian script and Ge'ez, the language of Aksum — and around this time Ge'ez writing began to mark vowels. [34][36]

Here the story of Aksum parts company with the story of Meroë. Ge'ez ceased to be spoken as an everyday language sometime between about 900 and 1200, but it never stopped being read. It continues today as a liturgical language. [37] And the script developed to write it is still used, in adapted form, for Amharic in Ethiopia and Tigrinya in Eritrea and Ethiopia. [36]

Meroë's letters can be sounded but not understood. Aksum's letters, in their modern forms, are read every day by millions of people writing Amharic and Tigrinya. The difference is not that one people was more intelligent than the other. It is that one set of letters was carried by an institution — a church, its schools, its scribes and its liturgy — that kept teaching them, generation after generation, through every change of dynasty. The other was not.

In 1937, during the Italian occupation of Ethiopia, one of the Aksum stelae was taken to Rome as a trophy. It stood there for

decades. Italy returned it in April 2005, and it was raised again at Aksum in 2008. [38] We will return in Chapter 10 to what it means when the monuments of a people are carried away, and what it means when they come home.

Egypt and the Question of Belonging

No discussion of the Nile can avoid the oldest argument of all: whether ancient Egypt belongs to African history.

Hegel answered no. In the same lectures in which he declared Africa "no historical part of the World", he divided the continent into parts and set the Nile valley apart from what he called Africa proper, treating Egypt as a bridge to Asia and Europe rather than an African achievement. [10] Generations of writers followed him, presenting Egypt as an honorary member of the Mediterranean or the Near East and leaving the rest of the continent without it.

The most forceful reply came from the Senegalese scholar Cheikh Anta Diop (1923–1986), whose *Nations nègres et culture* (1954) argued that ancient Egypt was a Black African civilisation whose language and culture were related to those of peoples further south and west. [39] Diop wrote the opening chapter on the origins of the ancient Egyptians for the second volume of UNESCO's *General History of Africa*, and in 1974 his thesis was debated at a symposium in Cairo. [32][39]

The published report of that meeting is a useful guide to what is settled and what is not. The scholars present broadly agreed that the population of the Nile valley had been stable since before the first dynasties, and the older picture of a uniformly light-skinned Egyptian population was quietly abandoned. They disagreed about whether the earliest population was homogeneously Black, as Diop and the Congolese scholar Théophile Obenga argued, or mixed, as others maintained, and about Diop's proposed links between ancient Egyptian and languages such as Wolof. One participant summarised a widely

shared view: the unity of the Egyptian people was cultural rather than racial. [32]

The debate has not ended. Many historians have criticised Diop's reliance on older racial categories and some of his linguistic methods, while others credit him with forcing scholarship to restore Egypt to African history. [39] In 2025 the committee responsible for the final volumes of the *General History of Africa* concluded that ancient Egypt had both African and Eurasian populations and identified Upper Egypt, in the south, as the origin of pharaonic unification. [40]

This book takes a position that does not depend on settling every detail of ancient skin colour. Egypt stands on African soil, drew on the Nile and the peoples of its southern valley, and was entwined with Kush for three thousand years. It belongs to African history. But it is not the only African civilisation, and African history does not need Egypt in order to be great. Kerma, Kush and Aksum did not borrow their importance from the pharaohs. They earned it.

The Letter Principle

Kush and Aksum built states that could raise armies, negotiate with emperors, mint coins, smelt iron and write in their own scripts. They also captured and enslaved. Both truths belong to the record. But their deepest lesson for this trilogy lies in what happened to their letters. A script survives as long as there are institutions that teach it, use it and hand it on. When the schools, the scribes and the courts that sustained Meroitic disappeared, its signs outlived their meaning. When a church kept teaching Ge'ez, its letters crossed fifteen centuries. Knowledge does not survive because it is carved in stone. It survives because people build arrangements that keep passing it on. A civilisation that does not organise its own continuity will one day have its words read aloud by strangers who cannot tell what they mean.

Questions for Reflection

1. Before reading this chapter, had you heard of Kush, Kerma or Aksum? Which did you know more about: these kingdoms, or ancient Rome?
2. The story of Amanirenas is often told as a victory over Rome. Why might a negotiated peace be a greater achievement than a battlefield victory?
3. Meroitic can be read aloud but not understood; Ge'ez is still read every week. What institutions in your own society keep knowledge alive across generations, and which are at risk?
4. Ezana's inscription counts prisoners alongside cattle. How should we hold admiration for ancient kingdoms together with the suffering their power caused?
5. Does it matter whether ancient Egypt is counted as African history? What changes for you if it is, and what remains true either way?

* * *

The head of Augustus no longer lies beneath the steps at Meroë. It sits behind glass in London, looking out at visitors who mostly do not know whose feet once passed over it.

The next chapter crosses the continent westward, to the Sahel, where gold moved north across the desert, scholars copied books in Timbuktu, and a king of Mali made a pilgrimage that people still talked about centuries later.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 3

Gold, Manuscripts, and the Cities of Knowledge

> *"They are seldom unjust, and have a greater abhorrence of injustice than any other people."*
>
> — Ibn Battuta, on the people of Mali, 1350s

In 1324 a king from the far west of Africa passed through Cairo on his way to Mecca. His name was Musa, and he ruled Mali, an empire that stretched across the grasslands south of the Sahara. He travelled with a great retinue, and he travelled with gold.

About twelve years later, a Damascus-born scholar and official named al-Umari set down what the people of Cairo remembered. He had asked an emir who had received the king, and the emir had told him of the sultan's opulence and piety. Musa, he wrote, "forwarded to the royal treasury many loads of unworked native gold and other valuables." He "left no court emir nor holder of a royal office without the gift of a load of gold." His people spent freely in the markets. "They exchanged gold until they depressed its value in Egypt and caused its price to fall," al-Umari recorded, adding: "This has been the state of affairs for about twelve years until this day." [41]

Half a century later, on a great map of the known world made on the Mediterranean island of Majorca, a cartographer painted a crowned African king seated on a throne. The caption reads: "This black Lord is called Musse Melly and is the sovereign of the land of the black people of Gineva." [42] Europe had begun to draw Africa's kings, and it drew this one holding gold.

The image has lasted. Mansa Musa is remembered today as the king so rich he crashed a currency. But gold does not dig itself up, carry itself across a desert or turn itself into books. Behind the pilgrimage stood something less dazzling and far more important: an arrangement of rulers, miners, merchants,

scholars, taxes, roads and laws that made the wealth possible and made it useful.

This chapter asks what that arrangement was. How did the societies of the Sahel turn gold and trade into states and scholarship, and who carried the cost?

Before Mali: The Kingdom Called Ghana

Mali was not the first great power of the western Sahel. Centuries earlier, Arabic writers described a kingdom they called Ghana.

Around 1068, in Córdoba in Muslim Spain, the geographer al-Bakri compiled an account of it from the reports of merchants and travellers. He never visited the region himself. "The City of Ghana consists of two towns situated on a plain," he wrote. One, "inhabited by Muslims, is large and possesses twelve mosques." The king's town, some miles away, was called al-Ghaba. Near the king's court of justice stood a mosque for Muslim visitors. [43]

Al-Bakri also recorded two rules that tell us how the kingdom worked. "The nuggets found in all the mines of his country are reserved for the king." And "on every donkey-load of salt when it is brought into the country their king levies one gold dinar." [43]

Those two sentences describe a state. The king controlled the largest pieces of the region's most valuable product and taxed the movement of its most needed import. Salt came south across the desert; gold went north. A kingdom that sat between them, kept the roads open and took its share could grow rich without owning either the salt pans or most of the gold fields. That is grammar: rules that turned trade into public revenue.

The capital itself remains a puzzle. For much of the twentieth century, archaeologists identified the ruins of Koumbi Saleh, in what is now south-eastern Mauritania, as the Muslim town al-Bakri described. More recent scholars have questioned the identification, and the king's town has never been found. [44] When the Gold Coast won its independence in 1957, it took the name of this ancient kingdom, even though medieval Ghana lay far to the north-west of the new nation's borders. [45] Like

Zimbabwe, a modern African state reached back for a name that colonial history had taught the world to forget.

The Word of the Griots

Mali's own account of its beginnings was not written in Arabic. It was spoken and sung.

Among the Mande peoples, hereditary specialists called *jeli* — often known in English by the French word *griots* — preserve genealogies, praise songs and the epic of Sunjata Keita, the founder of the empire. In the version most widely known outside West Africa, written down in French by the Guinean historian Djibril Tamsir Niane and published in 1960, Sunjata overcomes exile and disability, gathers allies and defeats the sorcerer-king Sumanguru at the battle of Krina, which tradition places in the 1230s. [46]

The epic is not a chronicle. It is a living work of memory, shaped by generations of tellers and by the families whose ancestors it honours. That makes it more valuable, not less. It tells us what the Mande remembered, what they believed a ruler owed his people, and which alliances they considered the foundations of their society. But it has to be read as what it is.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

In 2009 UNESCO inscribed the Manden Charter, proclaimed at Kurukan Fuga, on its list of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. UNESCO describes it as proclaimed in the early thirteenth century, after a major military victory, by the founder of the Mande empire and his assembly of wise men. Its provisions concern social peace in diversity, the inviolability of the human being, education, food security, the abolition of slavery by raiding, and freedom of expression and trade. Its words and rituals are still passed on orally, and ceremonies are held each year at Kangaba. [47]

On the internet, the charter has become something else: “the world’s first declaration of human rights,” often printed as a numbered list of forty-four articles and dated precisely to 1236.

That numbered text has a modern history. It was assembled at a regional workshop held in Kankan, Guinea, in 1998, where participants worked with oral traditions to “reconstruct” the charter, under the supervision of a member of the Kouyaté griot family. Niane himself described the reconstruction as a declaration on the rights of man. Historians have raised serious questions. The French historian Francis Simonis observed that no Malian griots were invited to the workshop and that the resulting text gives special prominence to the family that organised it. The Dutch anthropologist Jan Jansen has called it a recent invention rather than a credible historical document. [48]

None of this means the Mande had no ideas about rights, justice or limits on power. The tradition UNESCO recognised is real, and Ibn Battuta’s testimony, which we shall come to, suggests that Mali took justice seriously. What the evidence corrects is the form of the claim. The tradition is ancient; the article-by-article document is modern. To honour oral tradition is to understand how it works: as memory carried and reshaped by living people, not as a lost parchment waiting to be recovered word for word.

An African history that cannot tell the difference between the two will one day be embarrassed by its own enthusiasm. An African history that can tell the difference has nothing to fear from scrutiny.

A Kingdom Seen by a Stranger

In 1352 the Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta crossed the Sahara and spent months in Mali, during the reign of Musa’s brother Sulayman. He was a difficult guest. He complained about his reception and about customs that offended his sense of propriety. But he also left one of the most striking descriptions of any medieval state, written by a man with no reason to flatter it.

"They are seldom unjust, and have a greater abhorrence of injustice than any other people," he wrote. "There is complete security in their country. Neither traveller nor inhabitant in it has anything to fear from robbers or men of violence." And: "They do not confiscate the property of any white man who dies in their country, even if it be uncounted wealth." [49]

Read those sentences as a merchant would. A caravan crossing the Sahara risked everything: camels, goods, capital and life. It would make the journey only to places where roads were safe, contracts were honoured and the property of a foreigner who died far from home would reach his heirs. Security and the protection of property were not luxuries. They were the institutions on which the gold trade, and the empire, depended.

The same traveller recorded what else he saw. "The women servants, slave-girls, and young girls go about in front of everyone naked," he complained. [49] His objection was to their dress. What we notice is that slave-girls were an ordinary part of the society he was describing.

Timbuktu

Of all the cities of the Sahel, one became a byword. Timbuktu stood near the great bend of the Niger, where the river reaches furthest into the desert, and in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries it became an intellectual and spiritual capital of West Africa. [50]

Its three great mosques, Djingareyber, Sankore and Sidi Yahia, still stand. UNESCO credits the initial construction of Djingareyber to Kankan Moussa — Mansa Musa — on his return from the pilgrimage, and records that it was rebuilt and enlarged between 1570 and 1583 by the city's judge, Imam al-Aqib. The mosques are built of earth and kept standing by regular maintenance using traditional techniques. UNESCO's description of the city counts some 180 Qur'anic schools and 25,000 students in its golden age, when Sankore was a renowned centre of teaching. [50]

Earth architecture carries its own lesson. A stone wall can stand for centuries while the society that built it disappears. A mud mosque survives only if a community returns, season after season, to repair it. Timbuktu's mosques are monuments to continuous organisation.

The manuscripts tell the same story. The scholars of Timbuktu copied, studied and wrote works of law, theology, grammar, astronomy, medicine and commerce, and private families built libraries that they handed down for generations. The texts shown by the Library of Congress in 2003 included a treatise on the laws of commerce in verse and a primer of arithmetic. [22] Knowledge here was not a private gift. It was organised: taught, copied, stored, inherited and protected.

By the late fifteenth century, Timbuktu belonged to a new power. Sunni Ali, who ruled from about 1464 to 1492, built the empire of Songhai around the city of Gao and drove out the Tuareg, who had held Timbuktu since 1433. His successor Askia Muhammad, who ruled from 1493 to 1528, "welded the central region of the western Sudan into a single empire." At its height it reached from central Mali to the Atlantic and east into present-day Niger and Nigeria. [51] Its rulers had to balance the interests of pastoralist subjects who held to older religions and Muslim city dwellers on whose wealth and scholarship the empire depended. [51]

Who Carried the Weight

The cities of knowledge were also cities of bondage. The Timbuktu documents shown in 2003 included a contract concerning the sale and transport of enslaved people and a certificate freeing an enslaved woman. [22] Captives were among the goods that crossed the Sahara northward, alongside gold.

The most famous scholar of Timbuktu wrestled with this directly. Ahmad Baba (1556–1627), jurist and author of dozens of books, wrote a treatise on slavery known as *Mi'raj al-Su'ud*, *The*

Ladder of Ascent. In it he argued that free Muslims could not lawfully be enslaved and that buyers must establish a captive's religion before purchase. He rejected the idea that skin colour, or the supposed curse of Ham, could justify slavery. The only lawful ground, he held, was unbelief. [52]

That position deserves to be weighed carefully. Ahmad Baba confronted, centuries before the Atlantic abolitionists, the claim that Black people were destined for slavery, and refuted it. And in the same pages he accepted that non-Muslims could lawfully be enslaved. [52] The finest legal mind of the city reasoned against racial slavery and within religious slavery at once. Both facts belong to the history of Timbuktu, and neither cancels the other.

The Day the Scholars Were Taken

In 1591 an army sent by Ahmad al-Mansur, sultan of Morocco, crossed the Sahara. Using firearms, it defeated the Songhai army at Tondibi and went on to take Timbuktu and Gao. [51] The empire's economic and administrative centres stayed in Moroccan hands, and resistance failed to restore Songhai. [51]

In 1594 the occupiers accused Timbuktu's judge and other leading figures of subversion and deported them across the desert to Marrakesh. Ahmad Baba was among them. [52][53] In exile he taught and issued legal opinions admired for their clarity. He was allowed to go home only after the sultan's death in 1603, and did not reach Timbuktu until years later. [52][53]

We will examine conquest in Part Two. But note what this conquest took. Gold had made Songhai rich; it could not protect the scholars. An army with firearms carried off the minds that had made Timbuktu what it was. A city of knowledge can be emptied faster than it can be built.

The Librarians of Timbuktu

The manuscripts outlived the Moroccan conquest, colonial rule and independence. In 2012 they faced another war.

In March 2012, after a military coup in Bamako, armed Islamist groups took control of northern Mali, including Timbuktu. [54] They destroyed nine of the city's mausoleums of saints and the door of a mosque. In 2016 the International Criminal Court sentenced Ahmad al-Faqi al-Mahdi, who had led the destruction, to nine years in prison — the first person the court had ever convicted of destroying cultural heritage as a war crime. [55]

When the occupiers fled in January 2013, they set fire to manuscripts at the Ahmed Baba Institute, the public research library named after the scholar of the previous section. The city's mayor told a British newspaper: "They have burned the manuscripts." [56] The world mourned the loss of Timbuktu's libraries.

The loss was real. UNESCO later counted 4,203 manuscripts burned or stolen out of the institute's 46,000. [54] But most of the city's manuscripts had already gone.

Beginning in May 2012, Abdel Kader Haidara, a librarian whose family had kept manuscripts for generations, organised a quiet evacuation. Before dawn, staff wrapped the manuscripts and packed them into metal lockers. Couriers carried the lockers at night to the homes of Timbuktu families. By July, around 1,700 lockers were hidden across the city. From October they were moved south toward Bamako by pushcart, donkey cart, bus and truck; when fighting closed the roads in January 2013, they went down the Niger by boat. Haidara estimated that around 95 per cent of the city's 300,000 manuscripts reached safety. "If you lose a manuscript," he said, "it's gone forever." [56]

In 1594 the scholars of Timbuktu were carried off and their city could not stop it. In 2012 the descendants of its manuscript-keeping families carried the books out themselves. What saved them was not a government or an army. It was an old institution — families who had treated the keeping of knowledge as a duty passed from parent to child — combined with courage, organisation and trust among people who knew one another.

The Letter Principle

Gold is a letter. On its own it means nothing; flooded into a market, it can even destroy its own value, as Cairo learned in 1324. What gave the gold of the Sahel its meaning was the grammar around it: rulers who taxed trade instead of seizing it, roads where travellers had nothing to fear, laws that protected a dead stranger's property, scholars who turned wealth into books, and families who kept those books for centuries. The same grammar had its cruelties, and the trade that carried gold also carried captives. But the lesson of the Sahel is clear. Wealth does not make a civilisation. Arrangements that make people safe, keep knowledge moving and outlast any single king do.

Questions for Reflection

1. Mansa Musa is remembered mostly for his wealth. What does this chapter suggest was more important to Mali's power than gold itself?
2. Ibn Battuta praised Mali's security and justice. Which institutions in your country make a stranger, a trader or an investor feel safe, and which make them afraid?
3. The Manden Charter is a real tradition, but its forty-four-article version is modern. Why does it matter to distinguish the two, and what is lost if we do not?
4. Ahmad Baba argued against racial slavery while accepting religious slavery. How should we judge thinkers who were ahead of their time in one way and of their time in another?
5. The manuscripts of Timbuktu were saved in 2012 by families, not by the state. What knowledge does your family or community keep, and how is it being handed on?

* * *

The gold that Musa carried to Cairo has long since been melted into other people's coins. The books his city gathered are still being read.

The next chapter turns south and east, to the stone city of Great Zimbabwe, the merchants of the Swahili coast and the bronze-casters of Ife and Benin, to ask how people who never met one another built such different forms of meaning.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 4

Stone, Sea, and Bronze

> *"These issues evidently so beclouded the minds of scholars that for a long time, indeed until the late 20th century, they denied the art of Africa a proper place in the history of universal human creative endeavor."*
>
> — Ekpo Eyo, Nigerian archaeologist

On the last day of 1932, a man named Mowena led a small party of white prospectors to a sandstone hill near the place where the Limpopo and Shashe rivers meet, on the border of what are now South Africa, Botswana and Zimbabwe. The farmer E. S. J. van Graan, his son and three companions climbed it. On the summit they found stone walls, and in the soil they found gold, iron, pottery and glass beads. [57]

Mowena knew the hill already. The local name for it was Mapungubwe, usually translated "hill of the jackal". The prospectors had come with a guide; history would remember them as the discoverers. [57]

Van Graan's son recognised what they had found and reported it to the head of the history department at the University of Pretoria. Within months the government bought the farm, the university took ownership of the gold, and excavation began. [57] Among the burials on the hilltop the excavators found objects of gold: a foil bowl, a sceptre, and a small rhinoceros that has since become one of the most famous objects in South Africa. [59]

For decades, few South Africans learned what the hill meant. South African History Online notes that after the first wave of publicity the university's excavations and findings were kept fairly secret and only made public after 1994. [57] The historian and curator Sian Tiley-Nel, who has spent much of her career with the Mapungubwe archive, writes that its prehistory was excluded during apartheid to support Eurocentric views of the

country's past, and that some scholars attributed the site to "non-Africans". [58] The collection was made properly accessible to the public only after 1999. [58] For two generations, a gold rhinoceros lay in a university collection while the country was taught a history that began with European ships.

Chapter 1 followed one such argument to Great Zimbabwe. This chapter is less interested in who denied the builders than in what the builders built. Between the eleventh and the fifteenth centuries, people in the Limpopo valley, on the coast of East Africa and in the forests of what is now southern Nigeria organised themselves in strikingly different ways: around a sacred hill, around a harbour, around a guild of metal-casters. How did each arrangement turn stone, sea or bronze into shared meaning, and who carried its cost?

The Hill of the Jackal

Mapungubwe did not begin on the hill. Around the year 1000, a farming community established a capital at the foot of a neighbouring rise, at a site archaeologists call K2. Its people kept cattle, grew millet and sorghum, worked iron, and traded down the Limpopo towards the Indian Ocean: gold, ivory and hides went out; glass beads, cloth and cowrie shells came in. [59]

Then, around 1220, the arrangement changed. The ruler and his close family moved to the summit of Mapungubwe Hill, a kidney-shaped block of sandstone ringed by cliffs, with their court officials around them. The commoners stayed below. The archaeologist Thomas Huffman describes this as the moment a community ranked by kinship became a society divided by class. In his words, "Mapungubwe's architecture and spatial arrangement provide the earliest evidence for class distinction and sacred leadership in southern Africa." [59]

"Sacred leadership" meant that the ruler's authority rested on a relationship with the land, the ancestors and God, made visible in rainmaking. The hill had been a rainmaking place before any king lived on it; the ruler moved into an existing source of sacred

power and became its keeper. [59] Height, stone and seclusion did the work that a constitution does elsewhere. They told every person in the valley where authority sat.

Mapungubwe had no gold of its own. The nearest goldfields lay in what are now Botswana and south-western Zimbabwe; copper came from the Musina area and iron from further north. The metal reached the hill through exchange, and the evidence for working bronze and gold is concentrated on the summit, where the rulers could control it. [59] Power lay less in owning a resource than in standing at the junction where resources met.

The hill's rulers were not the only people involved. The archaeologist Tim Forssman and his team have excavated Little Muck Shelter, a painted rock shelter four kilometres south of the Limpopo, and found that hunter-gatherers were still living in the area while the kingdom rose. They made bone tools and traded with farmers, and they obtained the glass beads and metal that marked wealth in the new society. "We cannot think about Mapungubwe's history without including hunter-gatherer societies," Forssman writes. [60] Even the most hierarchical arrangement in the valley had more letters in it than the royal graves suggest.

By about 1290 the hill was abandoned. Huffman connects the end to a drier climate that undermined leaders whose legitimacy depended on rain; others point to a shift in the gold trade towards routes that bypassed the Limpopo. [59] The two explanations are not exclusive. What is clear is where the pattern went next: north, to the granite hills of the Zimbabwe plateau, where the rulers of Great Zimbabwe built on the same model of a sacred elite set apart in stone. [59]

From the Plateau to the Sea

Great Zimbabwe's walls have already had a chapter. Its economy belongs here. The archaeologist Shadreck Chirikure has argued that the households and local production of ordinary people explain the city at least as much as its rulers' imported luxuries

do. [4] Those luxuries still tell us where the region's gold went: Chinese and Persian porcelain and coins from Kilwa have been found at the site. [2]

The gold left the plateau by way of the coast. Sofala, on the shore of present-day Mozambique, was the principal outlet for the gold and ivory of the interior. By the late twelfth century, according to the chronicle tradition of the town, the rulers of Kilwa, an island far to the north off the coast of present-day Tanzania, had taken control of Sofala. [62] A stone city on the plateau and a stone city on the sea were joined by the same commodity, and neither could have prospered in the same way without the other.

In about 1331 the Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta, whom we met in Mali in Chapter 3, sailed down the coast from Mogadishu to Kilwa. [63] A merchant told him that Sofala lay a fortnight's journey south "and that gold dust is brought to Sufala from Yufi in the country of the Limis, which is a month's journey distant from it." [61] He was describing, at second hand, the chain that ran from the goldfields of the interior to the harbour where he stood.

His description of the town is brief. "Kulwa is a very fine and substantially built town, and all its buildings are of wood," runs the standard English translation. [61] Archaeology adds what a visitor might have missed. Stone building at Kilwa began around the thirteenth century; before that, every house was of wattle and daub, and archaeologists read a household's standing from the kind of house it lived in. [63] The ruins of Kilwa Kisiwani and nearby Songo Mnara, with their houses and mosques of stone and coral, are now a World Heritage site. [21]

The sultan at the time of his visit, Ibn Battuta wrote, was "noted for his gifts and generosity"; he had seen him give the clothes off his back to a beggar. [61] This ruler is generally identified with al-Hasan ibn Sulaiman, who enlarged the Great Mosque of Kilwa and built the palace of Husuni Kubwa on a bluff above the sea: a building of coral stone with a court used for commerce, more than a hundred rooms and a stairway down to a mosque on the beach. [63] It was a palace and a warehouse at

once. Kilwa's rulers did not separate government from trade, because trade was what they governed.

Kilwa was not an empire in the inland sense. At its height in the fifteenth century, its sultans claimed authority over towns from the Mozambique coast to the islands of Zanzibar and Pemba, but the sultanate worked more like a confederation of commercial cities, each with its own elite and merchant communities, than a centralised state. [62] The grammar of the coast was partnership and rivalry among towns that needed one another's harbours.

A Coast of Many Ancestors

The Swahili towns kept their own account of where they came from. Kilwa's chronicle tells of Ali ibn al-Hassan, a son of a ruler of Shiraz in Persia, who sailed to the coast and bought the island from its African ruler. [62] A view widespread in colonial times went further and held that Africans had contributed little to the towns at all — the Great Zimbabwe pattern again, this time with the sea for an alibi. Later, some scholars answered by minimising outside contributions altogether.

In 2023 the largest study of ancient African DNA yet published tested the question directly, using the remains of 80 people from the Swahili coast and its inland neighbours, dating from about 1300 to 1900. It found that from around the year 1000, migrants from south-west Asia, mainly Persian men, married into coastal African communities and contributed close to half the ancestry of the people studied. It also found that the hallmarks of Swahili civilisation predated their arrival. [65] The study's co-senior author, the anthropologist Chapurukha Kusimba, put it plainly: "Archaeological evidence overwhelmingly showed that the medieval Swahili civilization was an African one." [65]

The detail is more interesting than either old answer. The newcomers were mostly men, with a smaller contribution from Indian women; the women they married were overwhelmingly African. The children of Persian fathers grew up speaking their

mothers' language and living in their mothers' kinship systems; the primary language, tomb architecture, cuisine and matrilocal marriage of the coast remained African and Bantu in character. The geneticist David Reich suggests that the newcomers "allied with and married into local trading families and adopted local customs to enable them to be more successful traders." [65] The findings, the researchers note, align with the oldest Swahili oral traditions of Shirazi arrivals. [65] The oral tradition was not wrong. It was incomplete in a way the colonial reading made worse.

The language tells the same story. Swahili is a Bantu language of the Sabaki branch, closely related to the languages of the Mijikenda and others on the coast. Perhaps 40 per cent of its vocabulary comes from Arabic, including its name, from an Arabic word meaning "of the coasts"; its grammar remains Bantu. The earliest known documents written in Swahili are letters sent from Kilwa in 1711, in Arabic script. [64] A borrowed word can enter a language without changing its grammar. That is a fair summary of the medieval coast.

The Heads of Ife

On the other side of the continent, in the forest country of the Yoruba, lies the city of Ife, which the Yoruba regard as a sacred city founded by the gods and the birthplace of humanity. Between about the twelfth and fifteenth centuries its artists made heads of terracotta and copper alloy of extraordinary naturalism. [66]

In 1910 the German ethnologist Leo Frobenius spent about three weeks in Ife. He was taken to a sacred grove where a copper-alloy head lay ritually buried, associated with Olokun, the god of the sea. He called it "a head of marvelous beauty, wonderfully cast in antique bronze, true to life, encrusted with a patina of glorious dark green." He pressed the priest of the grove to sell it, reportedly for six pounds. Ife's elders protested, the British colonial administration intervened, and Frobenius was

made to return the head, though he took several terracottas to Germany. [66]

He could not accept that Africans had made it. He proposed instead that survivors of the lost Atlantis had carried Greek civilisation to West Africa, and that Olokun was the Greek sea god Poseidon. The head, he wrote, showed "a symmetry, a vitality, reminiscent of Greece and a proof that, once upon a time, a race, far superior in strain to the Negro, had been settled here." [66] Mauch had found the Queen of Sheba in a Zimbabwean valley. Frobenius found Atlantis in a Yoruba grove. The method was the same: admire the work, then remove the authors.

The evidence came out of the ground. In 1938 more than a dozen copper-alloy heads were found in Ife, and by 1948 archaeologists accepted that they were the work of Yoruba artists. [66] Study has shown that the heads represent not gods but rulers, the *ooni* of Ife. In Yoruba thought, the head is the seat of *ori*, a person's inner self and destiny. [66] To make a ruler's head was to make an image of the place where his fate resided.

When the heads were exhibited at the British Museum in 1948, a London publication declared: "This African art is worthy to rank with the finest works of Italy and Greece." [66] It was meant as the highest praise. It also shows how far the measure still lay outside Africa. The Nigerian archaeologist Ekpo Eyo later wrote that scholars had for a long time "denied the art of Africa a proper place in the history of universal human creative endeavor." [66] The heads of Ife did not need to rank with Greece. They needed to be seen as what they were.

The Guild and the King

South-east of Ife lay the kingdom of Benin, ruled by the Edo people and their king, the *oba*, whose art would become even better known.

Benin remembers Ewuare, who took the throne around 1440 after a violent struggle with his brother that destroyed much of the city, as the king who remade it. According to the traditions

recorded by later historians, he rebuilt the capital, expanded the kingdom, reduced the power of the hereditary chiefs called the *uzama*, who had chosen earlier kings, and established succession by the eldest son. He also created new orders of town and palace chiefs appointed by and accountable to the oba. [67] The office of king grew stronger by taking powers that had belonged to others.

The bronze-casters were part of this arrangement. In Benin they formed a hereditary guild, the Igun-Eronmwon, whose members claim descent from a small number of founding families and who cast for the oba, his chiefs and priests. The kings granted them the exclusive right to the craft in return for serving the palace. In the early sixteenth century Oba Esigie gave them their own quarter and confirmed their monopoly, and casting flourished into the great series of brass plaques that recorded court life. [68] The guild still works on Igun Street in Benin City. [68]

A guild is grammar of a particular kind. It protects knowledge by restricting who may hold it, passes skill from parent to child, and ties a craft to a patron. The arrangement produced some of the finest metalwork in the world. It also meant that the art belonged, in a real sense, to the king.

From the late 1480s Benin had a new trading partner. The Portuguese kept a post at the port of Ughoton for some thirty years from 1487. The oba controlled the kingdom’s trade with outsiders and personally owned most of its high-value goods, among them ivory, pepper, coral and leopard skins. In 1514 the oba sent an embassy to the Portuguese court, apparently hoping to obtain firearms. [69] Benin dealt with Europe as a state that set terms, not as a coast waiting to be found. What happened to the kingdom in 1897 belongs to Chapter 10.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

Benin is also the subject of one of the most widely shared claims about African history: that the walls of Benin were four times longer than the Great Wall of China.

The figure comes from serious work. In the late 1960s and early 1970s the archaeologist Patrick Darling, then a teacher in Nigeria, began surveying the banks and ditches — in Edo, *iya* — that run through the forest around Benin City. He used an orienteering compass and paced the distances himself. Earlier mapping by the archaeologist Graham Connah had found about one kilometre of earthwork for every square kilometre of land. Applying that density to the 6,500 square kilometres over which the earthworks extended, Darling estimated their total length at about 10,000 miles, some 16,000 kilometres. In his own account, that made them "the world's longest ancient earthworks, some four or five times longer than the main Great Wall of China." [70] The *Guinness Book of Records* adopted the claim; its current entry still credits the earthworks of Benin and Ishan with an estimated 16,000 kilometres and some 150 million cubic metres of earth moved. [71]

So the number is real. But it is an estimate, extrapolated from density over an area, and it describes something different from what the slogan implies. The earthworks were not one wall built by one king. Connah's mapping, as Darling describes it, showed a composite of many separate settlements divided by wide bands of no-man's-land, progressively enclosed and fused over the centuries. Benin's court history remembered concentric city walls, the innermost dug by Oba Oguola and deepened by Ewuare. Darling concluded that the tradition of three concentric walls was no longer credible, and that the evidence pointed to a pattern of rural enclosure that predated the Benin dynasty, though he cautioned that no simple interpretation was secure. [70] Guinness's own summary notes that they may first have been dug to keep elephants out of farmland, and that they came to serve as agricultural and social boundaries. [71] NASA,

describing satellite images of their remains in 2025, calls them a "vast, cellular network" built in sections over hundreds of years. [72]

The comparison with China is also slippery. Darling compared the earthworks with the "main" Great Wall. In 2012 China's State Administration of Cultural Heritage completed a five-year survey that measured the whole system of Great Wall fortifications, including branches and spurs, at 21,196 kilometres. [73] Measured against that, the earthworks of Benin are shorter. Measured against the main wall, they are longer. The answer depends on what is being counted, and the two structures were built for different purposes.

None of this diminishes Benin. It changes the achievement. The slogan imagines a king commanding a single wall. The evidence describes thousands of farming communities, over many generations, digging boundaries that ordered land, marriage and protection, until their combined labour formed the largest earthworks made before machines. That is not a smaller story. It is a story about letters as well as kings.

Who Carried the Weight

Each of these arrangements was built on unequal burdens.

At Mapungubwe, preparing the hilltop for the rulers required the mobilisation of a large workforce, and the royal court controlled the cattle and the precious metals. Refuse from the commoners' settlement shows that rich and poor ate very different food. [59] The class division Huffman describes as a milestone in political complexity was, for those at the bottom of the hill, a division.

At Kilwa, the generosity Ibn Battuta admired had a source. "Its inhabitants are constantly engaged in military expeditions," he wrote, "for their country is contiguous to the heathen Zanj," and the sultan devoted a fifth of "the booty made on his expeditions" to pious and charitable purposes. [61] Charity at home was funded in part by raids on neighbours whom the town called

unbelievers. Nor was generosity guaranteed. The sultan's brother and successor, Ibn Battuta reported, told petitioners: "He who gave is dead, and left nothing behind him to be given." [61]

At Benin, the oba's control of trade included control over the sale of people. According to one modern account, he prohibited the sale of male slaves after 1516 because he needed men for his own army. [69] The restriction was a measure of the kingdom's strength, not a rejection of slavery. And the brass from which the famous bronzes were cast came, in large part, from the Atlantic trade. In 2023 a team led by Tobias Skowronek compared the chemistry of the Benin works with brass rings called manillas, used as currency in the European trade with West Africa, and identified the German Rhineland as the principal source of the manillas used in that trade between the fifteenth and eighteenth centuries. [74] Among the manillas they analysed were 768 recovered from the wreck of the *Whydah Gally*, a ship whose trade goods were destined for the West African slave trade. [74] The metal of Benin's court art passed through the same commerce that, in time, would carry millions of Africans across the ocean. Chapter 6 follows that commerce.

The Letter Principle

There is no single ladder of civilisation, with Greece at the top and everyone else climbing towards it. At Mapungubwe, people arranged themselves around a sacred hill and a ruler set apart in stone. At Kilwa, they arranged themselves around a harbour, and grandmothers kept a Bantu language alive in the homes of Persian merchants. In Ife and Benin, they arranged skill into guilds and authority into kingship, and made faces in metal that still stop strangers in museum galleries. Each arrangement produced its own meaning, and each placed its burdens on particular people. Different letters, different grammars, different sentences. The mistake of Mauch and Frobenius was to believe that only one sentence counted as writing. The opposite mistake is to read every sentence as a hymn.

Questions for Reflection

1. Mowena guided the prospectors to Mapungubwe, but history remembered them as its discoverers. Whose knowledge in your community is used without being credited?
2. At Mapungubwe, authority was expressed by height and seclusion; at Kilwa, by a palace that was also a warehouse. What do the buildings of power in your country say about the relationship between rulers and people?
3. The 2023 DNA study found that the children of Persian fathers spoke their African mothers' language. What does this suggest about who really carries a culture from one generation to the next?
4. Frobenius admired the Ife heads but denied their makers. Where do you see admiration for African work combined with doubt about African authorship today?
5. The Benin earthworks are often presented as one king's wall, but the evidence points to many communities over many centuries. Which achievements in your own society are credited to one leader that were really built by many people?

* * *

A gold rhinoceros, a coral palace, a bronze head and a ditch in the forest: none of them was made by a single person, and none of them explains itself. Each is the trace of an arrangement among people who decided, under pressure and with unequal power, how to live and work together.

The next chapter asks how those arrangements of power were built: in kingdoms such as Buganda, Bunyoro, Kooki and Asante, and in societies that deliberately refused to have kings at all.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

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